Think aloud

Making expert thinking visible

Use a think aloud when the important learning sits in the choices an expert makes. Show how you plan, monitor and evaluate, including why you reject an attractive alternative.

How to do it well

1 **Clarify the task.** Read the demand and state the goal before starting.

2 **Connect to prior knowledge.** Identify a similar task, concept or strategy and explain the link.

3 **Plan and predict.** State the intended approach and anticipate where difficulty or error may occur.

4 **Verbalise reasoning.** Explain why each decision or method is chosen.

5 **Monitor and adjust.** Pause, notice when something looks wrong, check and troubleshoot visibly.

6 **Reflect and evaluate.** Summarise what worked, what could improve and what to do next time.

What this sounds like

“My first thought is to use this quotation, but it describes the setting. I need evidence about the character’s motive, so I will choose this line instead.”

Classroom example. An English teacher models selecting evidence. The think aloud explains why an attractive quotation does not support this particular claim, then identifies a better one. During guided practice, pupils name the feature that makes their own quotation relevant. The model reveals a decision they can reuse rather than just the chosen sentence.

Top tips that make the technique work

Script the consequential decisions. Identify a few places where your reasoning adds value, rather than narrating every movement.

Model monitoring. Show how you notice an implausible answer or a weak sentence and decide what to check.

Explain a rejected option. Students often need to hear why a familiar approach does not fit this task.

Make the thinking transferable. Name the clue, rule or criterion students can use on another example.

Hand over the self-talk. During guided practice, ask students to articulate the same planning or checking move in their own words.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Narrate planning, checking and revision.	A stream of unrelated inner commentary.
Keep the model focused on the learning decision.	Pretending every expert decision is immediate and certain.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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